

gaming industry as it comes with a job guarantee. It also has comprehensive career services, which will train aspirants in resume-building, polishing their LinkedIn profile, and preparing for a mock interview.

The program also offers many opportunities for the learners to interact with industry professionals across the spectrum of gaming & esports and gain a first-hand account of how the industry works. Moreover, we believe in a customised approach to learning and strive towards understanding the skill set of each learner and map their aspirations towards the opportunities. Lastly, this program ends with a guided industry project which is supported by industry experts. Interestingly, depending on the quality some learners will get the opportunity to publish their games they have developed on a publisher's platform.

Q How are you collaborating with gaming companies to offer a functional, useful and well-rounded gaming and esports course?

A As I mentioned above, one of our strengths is our industry connection. We are closely collaborating with industry experts and partners to understand the skillsets in demand and prepare learners for futuristic roles. While designing this program, we collaborated with leading local and international studios and publishing houses to understand the gaps, and the program will aim to bridge this gap. In addition to NODWIN Gaming, the program has UNITY, NSDC, and MESC as certificate partners and GameEon, HolyCow Productions, Godspeed Games, and Moonfrog as industry partners. The learning opportunity enabled by the program is vast and is the perfect foundation to kickstart a lucrative career in esports.

Q What has been the reaction of students and aspirants to enrol for a certification course in gaming and eSports?

A We have received an overwhelming response from aspirants, and we are enthused to see the passion and interest shown in this new-age program. It has attracted a very diverse set

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Founder and CEO,
Hero Vired



of learners from different walks of life, such as law, engineering, animation, textile design, tourism etc. and are at different stages in their careers. The first batch is completely sold out, and we have now opened enrolments for the second batch.

Q How will your certification course help students excel and succeed in the gaming and esports industry?

A This unique and comprehensive program is in line with Hero Vired's vision to offer industry first, new-age programs across immersive and futuristic sectors and make learners future-ready. With the best-in-class industry partners, we aim to equip all interested students with the desired knowledge and skills to excel in this fast-growing industry. Learners who opt for gaming as a specialisation, will be offered roles such as game developer, game artist, game designer, game audio engineer, etc. The ones who pursue esports as a specialisation, will be offered roles in league operations, community management, game marketing, event management, etc.

Q What are your thoughts on the state of gaming and esports in India, some of the challenges and opportunities ahead?

A I think 2022 has been the most exciting year for gaming and esports enthusiasts globally. The first-ever Commonwealth Esports Championship being held earlier this year is testimony to the fact that it is being considered a serious form of the sport by everyone. In fact, India's stellar performance was acknowledged with a bronze medal win by the Indian DOTA 2 squad!

The pandemic spurred the growth of India's gaming and esports industry. During the lockdown, millions picked up gaming recreationally, with some even making it a full-time profession. The lockdown increased the average daily screen time, which provided a fillip to the industry.

Over the years, affordable smart-phones, deeper penetration of internet connectivity, the emergence of new-age technologies, and, more recently, the advent of 5G have fuelled the growth of the industry.

There has also been a tremendous increase in the number of gamers from Tier-2 and Tier-3 cities in India, primarily mobile gaming. Moreover, many of these recreational gamers are women who picked it up as a hobby during the lockdown but have continued to pursue it even now.

The biggest challenge gamers pose, nowadays, is the high price of gaming hardware and software. Often, the success of a game is directly related to its visuals and graphics. This requires aspiring gamers to invest heavily in hardware and software capable of delivering these visuals. The challenge of highly-priced gaming hardware has unearthed a unique opportunity for entrepreneurship. India is starting to see a surge in the number of gaming cafes, a mega business opportunity, given its ability to entertain audiences at a fraction of the cost. The advent of 5G, the emergence of new-age technology, including Augmented Reality, and, more recently, the Metaverse imply that the industry is poised for a bright future. **■**